



▲ CRATERS AND CRATER LAKES OF RUAPEHU

Kata Tjuta

Location In the south of Northern Territory, Australia

This spectacular group of 36 domed rock formations towers high above the surrounding countryside and is visible from a great distance. The structures are composed of conglomerate, a mixture of rounded boulders in a sandstone matrix. Their orange–red hue is due to a thin cover of iron oxide. The biggest of the domes is Mount Olga, which stands 1,791 ft (546 m) above the plain.

Waimangu

Location North Island, New Zealand

In June 1886, New Zealand’s largest eruption in 700 years created the Waimangu Volcanic Rift Valley, which has been a hotspot of hydrothermal activity ever since and has a number of dramatic features. Acidic Frying Pan Lake is the largest hot spring on Earth. Nearby Inferno Crater Lake contains the largest geyserlike feature in the world—although it can’t be seen because it jets into the bottom of the deep lake.

Ruapehu

Location North Island, New Zealand

New Zealand’s largest active volcano, and North Island’s tallest mountain, Ruapehu has three peaks surrounding a crater, which becomes a crater lake between eruptions. One feature of Ruapehu eruptions has been the breaching of the lake dam and the creation of destructive lahars (mudflows) as water mixes with volcanic sediments and speeds downslope. A lahar

in 1953 killed 151 people. The last major eruption was in 1995, although there have been smaller events since.

Other mountains and volcanoes in Australia and New Zealand

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